



Saint Columban College
College of Computing Studies
Pagadian City



Riddle Registry

Riddle Registry 



Easy

Forensics

picoMini by CMU-Africa

browser_webshell_solvable

AUTHOR: PRINCE NIYONSHUTI N.

Description

Hi, intrepid investigator! 🕵️ You've stumbled upon a peculiar PDF filled with what seems like nothing more than garbled nonsense. But beware! Not everything is as it appears. Amidst the chaos lies a hidden treasure—an elusive flag waiting to be uncovered. Find the PDF file here [Hidden Confidential Document](#) and uncover the flag within the metadata.

Hints 

1 2

Don't be fooled by the visible text; it's just a decoy!

34,298 users solved



95% Liked



picoCTF{FLAG}

Submit Flag

Author: The Analyst: Hyposelenia

Challenge: Riddle Registry

Category: Forensics

Date: 03/07/26



I. Objective

The objective of this challenge is to analyze a provided PDF file and investigate hidden information within its metadata to discover the concealed flag.

II. Background

In digital forensics, files often contain **metadata**, which is additional information stored inside a file that describes details such as the author, creation date, editing software, and other attributes. While metadata is not normally visible when viewing a document, it can sometimes reveal hidden information or clues.

Attackers and investigators alike analyze metadata because developers or document creators may accidentally store sensitive data inside these fields. In this challenge, the flag was hidden within the **PDF metadata**, requiring inspection and decoding to retrieve it.

III. Tool Used

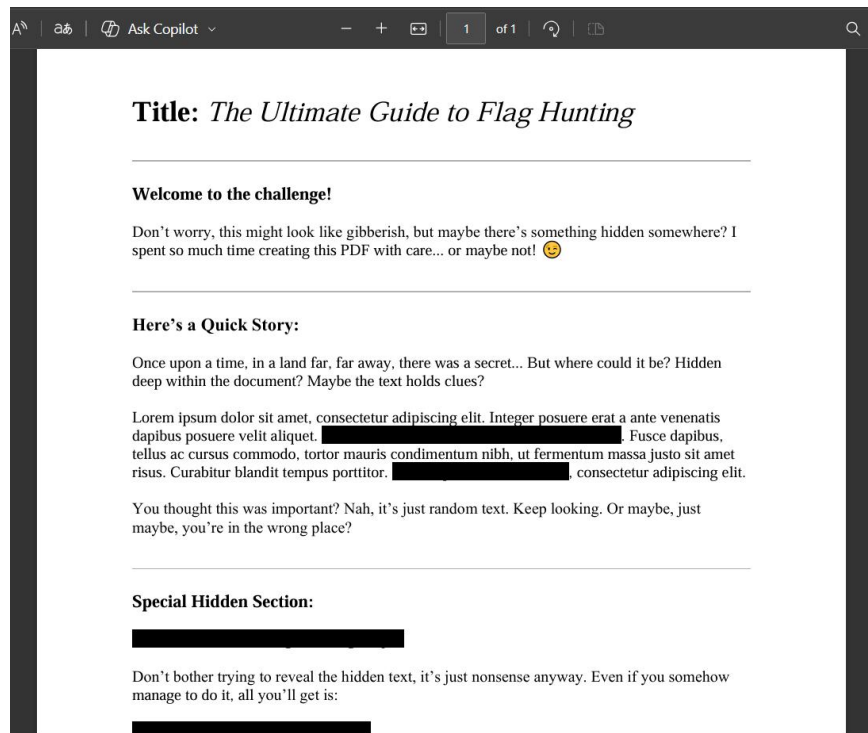
- PDF Viewer (Web Browser / Document Reader) ☐ Used to open and examine the provided PDF file.
- Base64 Decoder ☐ Used to decode encoded text discovered within the PDF metadata.

IV. Methodology

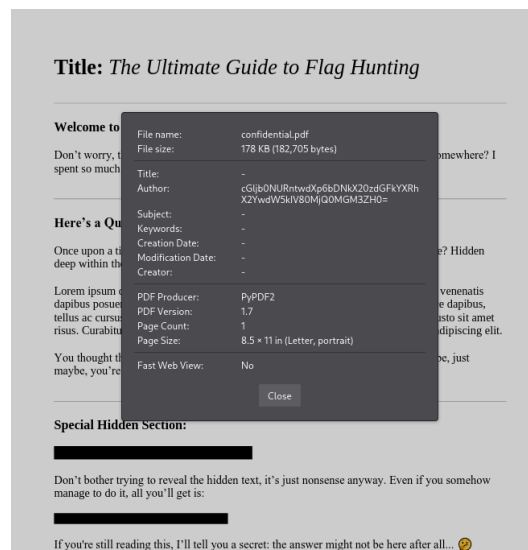
1. Downloaded and opened the PDF file provided in the challenge description.



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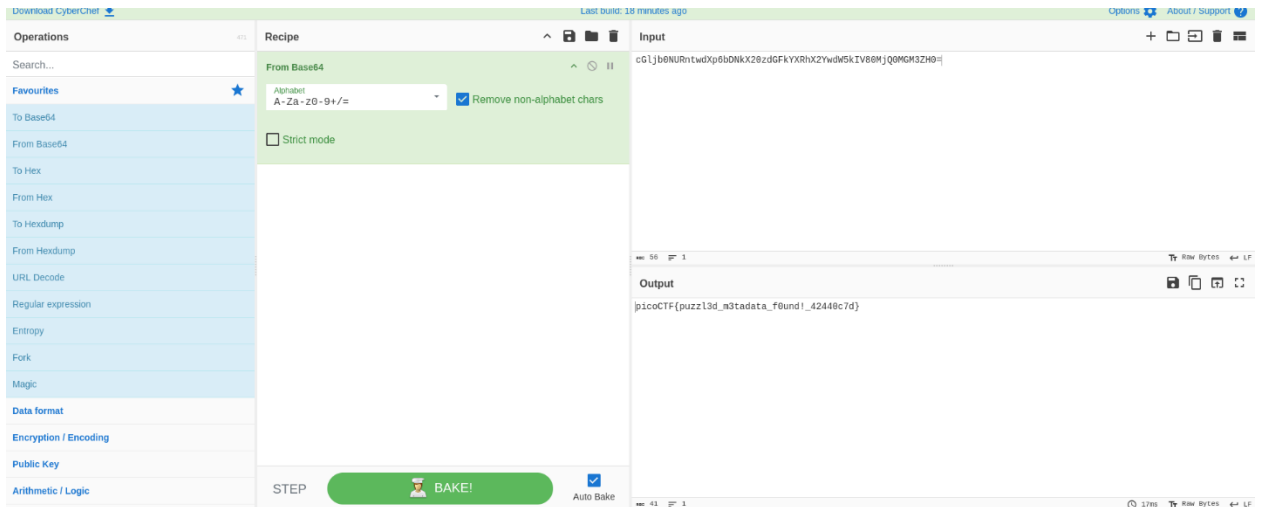


2. Attempted to highlight the redacted text within the document and pasted it on notepad to see if any hidden content was still present, but the results produced characters that aren't flag.
3. Checked the **document properties** to inspect the PDF metadata.
4. Observed that the **Author field contained a string resembling Base64 encoding**, which typically consists of letters, numbers, and sometimes ends with = characters.





5. Copied the suspected Base64 string.
6. Used a Base64 decoder to decode the string.



7. The decoded output revealed the hidden flag.

V. Result

picoCTF{puzzl3d_m3tadata_f0und!_42440c7d}



VI. Explanation

This challenge demonstrates how **hidden information can exist within file metadata**.



When a file such as a PDF is created, the software often stores additional details inside the document. These details may include:

- Author name
- Creation date
- Modification history
- Software used to create the document

Although users normally focus only on the visible content of a document, investigators often inspect metadata because it can contain valuable clues.

In this case, the **Author metadata field contained an encoded string**. The pattern of characters indicated that it was likely **Base64 encoding**, which is a method used to represent data using readable characters.

Base64 is **not encryption**, meaning it can easily be reversed. By decoding the Base64 string, the original hidden message was revealed, which contained the challenge flag.

This demonstrates an important concept in digital forensics: **sensitive information may remain hidden in metadata even when it is not visible in the document itself**.

VII. Conclusion

The Riddle Registry challenge highlights the importance of analyzing file metadata during forensic investigations. By examining the PDF's properties and identifying an encoded string within the metadata, the hidden flag was successfully recovered. This challenge reinforces the idea that valuable information may exist beyond the visible content of a file, making metadata analysis a critical skill in cybersecurity and digital forensics.

— **The Analyst: Hyposelenia**